VIT Bhopal University

VITyarthi E-Learning Platform

CSE0001 – Digital Literacy

Project Report

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Year	First Year B.Tech
Course Code	CSE0001
Date of Submission	31 March 2026

Introduction

This project report is submitted in partial fulfilment of the CSE0001 – Digital Literacy course, offered to all first-year B.Tech students at VIT Bhopal University through the VITyarthi E-Learning Platform. The course is a one-credit, Pass/Fail subject designed to equip students with foundational digital skills relevant to academic life and the professional world.

The project is framed around a real-world scenario: I have been selected as a Student Digital Ambassador, and my responsibility is to help my batchmates navigate the digital world responsibly and effectively. To fulfil this role, I have completed five tasks — each aligned to one of the five course modules — covering digital literacy awareness, professional online presence, coding and collaboration platforms, professional communication, and cybercrime awareness.

All deliverables, including screenshots, email drafts, checklists, and this report, are organized within a single public GitHub repository. No prior coding knowledge was required, and all tools used are free and browser-based. This report documents my work, observations, and personal reflections for each task.

Task 1 – Digital Literacy Awareness Infographic

Tool Used

For this task, I used Canva (canva.com), a free, browser-based graphic design platform that offers hundreds of ready-made infographic templates. No installation was required, and the platform was intuitive to use even without prior design experience.

What the Infographic Shows

I designed a single-page infographic titled 'Be Digitally Literate – A Student's Guide.' The infographic is divided into three clearly labelled sections, each covering one of the required topics:

- What Digital Literacy Is: This section defines digital literacy as the ability to find, evaluate, create, and communicate information using digital technologies responsibly. It highlights that digital literacy is more than just knowing how to use devices — it includes critical thinking online, understanding data privacy, and protecting one's digital identity.
- Safe Internet Practices: This section uses simple icons and short tips to convey five core safety habits — using strong passwords, enabling two-factor authentication, avoiding unknown links, not sharing personal information publicly, and verifying sources before sharing information.
- Professional Online Presence: This section briefly explains the importance of platforms like LinkedIn and GitHub for college students, and lists three key rules: keep profiles updated, use a professional photograph, and never post content that could embarrass you professionally.

Reflection

The most challenging aspect was making the infographic visually balanced — I initially overcrowded the slide with text, which made it hard to read. After two revisions, I reduced the text and used icons to replace lengthy explanations. What I found most interesting was discovering how much information can be communicated through visual hierarchy alone; once I arranged elements by importance and used consistent colours, the design became far more readable. This task gave me a new appreciation for the role design plays in communication.

Task 2 – Student Digital Portfolio

Platforms Set Up

For this task, I created and configured accounts on three platforms: GitHub, LinkedIn, and Kaggle. Each serves a distinct purpose in the professional and academic ecosystem for a Computer Science student.

- GitHub (github.com): GitHub is the world's largest platform for hosting and sharing code. It uses a version control system called Git, which allows developers to track changes in their code, collaborate with others, and contribute to open-source projects. I created a profile README repository — a special public repository named after my username — and added my name, branch, current year, and a short sentence about what I hope to learn during my B.Tech programme.
- LinkedIn (linkedin.com): LinkedIn is the leading professional networking platform, used by recruiters, companies, and working professionals worldwide. I set up my profile with my Education section filled in, listing VIT Bhopal University, my branch, and my expected graduation year. LinkedIn will be important when I begin applying for internships in my second or third year.
- Kaggle (kaggle.com): Kaggle is a data science and machine learning platform owned by Google. It hosts datasets, competitions, and free learning courses. Even though I am in my first year and have limited knowledge of data science, creating an account now allows me to explore beginner-level courses and start building a presence in the data community early.

Plans for the Next Four Years

I plan to use GitHub to store all my coding assignments, personal projects, and eventually open-source contributions. By the time I graduate, I want my GitHub profile to serve as a living portfolio of my technical skills. LinkedIn will be used actively from my second year onwards for networking, internship applications, and following industry professionals. On Kaggle, I plan to complete the beginner machine learning courses by the end of my first year and attempt my first competition by second year.

Task 3 – Coding and Collaboration Platforms

Part A – Coding Practice Platform

For the coding practice component, I chose HackerRank (hackerrank.com). HackerRank offers structured problem sets across multiple programming languages and difficulty levels, making it particularly suitable for beginners. After creating my account, I completed the 'Solve Me First' challenge — a beginner-level problem that requires reading two integers and printing their sum. While simple, this challenge helped me understand the HackerRank interface, including how to read input, write code in the browser-based editor, and submit solutions for automated testing.

Upon completion, I received a score and the problem was marked as solved on my profile. I also began the Python Introduction domain, which offers a sequence of challenges starting from basic syntax. Screenshots of my completed challenge and profile are saved in the task-3-platforms/ folder of my repository.

Part B – Google Workspace Collaboration

For the mandatory collaboration component, I created a Google Form titled 'Digital Literacy Awareness Quiz for B.Tech Students.' The form contains exactly five questions designed to test basic digital literacy knowledge:

- What does 'digital literacy' mean? (Multiple choice — 4 options)
- Which of the following is a safe internet practice? (Multiple choice — 4 options)
- Name one platform you would use to showcase your coding projects. (Short answer)
- True or False: You should use the same password for all your online accounts. (Multiple choice)
- What is two-factor authentication, and why is it important? (Short answer — paragraph)

I linked the form to a Google Sheet to automatically capture responses, and a screenshot of both the form and the linked spreadsheet (response view) is included in task-3-platforms/. The form link is also shared in my repository README.

Reflection

These tools will support my academic journey in meaningful ways. HackerRank will help me prepare for technical interviews and sharpen problem-solving skills consistently.

Google Forms is immediately useful — I can use it for peer surveys, club sign-ups, feedback collection, and now, actual quizzes for my role as a Digital Ambassador. Learning these tools early removes friction from future projects and collaborations.

Task 4 – Professional Email and Etiquette Guide

Email Drafts

Both professional emails are saved in full in the task-4-email-etiquette/ folder. Below is a summary of the structure and approach taken for each.

Email 1 — Request for Assignment Deadline Extension

Subject	Request for Extension – [Assignment Name] – [Your Name] – [Reg. No.]
Greeting	Dear Professor [Last Name],
Body Summary	Politely explains the reason for requesting an extension (e.g., illness or overlapping deadlines), specifies the requested new deadline, and assures the professor of commitment to submitting quality work.
Sign-off	Yours sincerely, [Full Name], [Reg. No.], [Branch], [Year]

Email 2 — Internship Expression of Interest

Subject	Application for Summer Internship Opportunity – [Your Name] – VIT Bhopal University
Greeting	Dear [Mr./Ms. Last Name] / Dear Hiring Team,
Body Summary	Introduces the sender, states the degree programme and institution, briefly expresses genuine interest in the company, mentions relevant skills or coursework, and requests consideration for a summer internship.
Sign-off	Yours sincerely, [Full Name], [Reg. No.], VIT Bhopal University | [Your Email] | [Phone — optional]

Communication Scenario – Reflection

One notable example of poor digital communication involves a case that has been widely discussed in academic institutions across India: a student posted a casual rant on social media about a faculty member's teaching style, tagging the university's official account. The post used informal language and included sarcastic remarks. Although the student intended it as a joke, the post went viral within the campus community, was screenshot and shared by others, and eventually reached the faculty member and the department head. The student faced a formal disciplinary inquiry.

What could have been done differently: The student could have used an internal feedback form or approached a student counsellor to raise concerns constructively. Even if using social media, removing the tag, avoiding personal remarks, and framing the concern objectively would have made the post far less harmful. This situation illustrates that once something is posted online, the poster loses control over how it is received and shared.

Task 5 – Cybercrime Awareness Case Study and Prevention Guide

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Case Study: UPI / Online Payment Fraud

The case study document is saved in full in task-5-cybercrime/casestudy.md. A summary is provided below.

UPI (Unified Payments Interface) fraud is one of the most prevalent forms of cybercrime targeting college students and young adults in India. In this type of fraud, the attacker typically contacts the victim through WhatsApp, Instagram DMs, or a phone call, pretending to be a buyer interested in an item listed for sale on OLX or a similar second-hand marketplace. The attacker claims they will pay via UPI and sends a 'collect request' or a QR code that, when scanned, deducts money from the victim's account rather than depositing it.

In a realistic scenario: a first-year student lists their old laptop on OLX. A 'buyer' contacts them, agrees on the price of Rs. 18,000, and says they will send a UPI payment immediately. They send a QR code and ask the student to scan it to 'receive' the money. The student scans the code, enters their UPI PIN, and Rs. 18,000 is deducted from their account. The attacker then disconnects.

This scam exploits a simple but critical misunderstanding: scanning a QR code or accepting a collect request always initiates a payment out of your account. You never need to enter your UPI PIN to receive money. Victims are typically students and first-time digital payment users who are unfamiliar with how UPI collect requests work. Consequences include financial loss, psychological distress, and delays in resolution due to limited awareness of the complaint process.

Reflection on Research

What surprised me most during my research was how straightforward and repeatable these scams are — the attacker does not need any hacking skills. They exploit social trust and a genuine knowledge gap about how UPI works. The same script is used hundreds of times on different victims. I was also surprised to learn that the National Cyber Crime Portal (cybercrime.gov.in) and helpline 1930 exist specifically for these situations, yet very few students I spoke with were aware of them.

One habit I will personally change as a result of this research is to never enter my UPI PIN in response to a request from someone I do not know in person, regardless of how

convincing the explanation sounds. I will also save the number 1930 in my contacts so I can report suspicious activity immediately if needed.

Conclusion

This project has been a practical and meaningful introduction to the skills I will need throughout my engineering degree and career. Across five tasks, I have built my first professional online profiles, created a digital awareness resource, practised using coding and collaboration platforms, learned how to communicate professionally via email, and studied one of the most common cybercrimes targeting students in India.

The most valuable takeaway is that digital literacy is not a single skill but a mindset — one that requires continuous learning, critical thinking, and responsible behaviour online. The GitHub repository I have created as part of this project will serve as the foundation of my professional digital portfolio for the next four years.

References

- Canva (canva.com) – Used for Task 1 infographic design
- GitHub (github.com) – Platform used for repository creation and portfolio setup (Task 2)
- LinkedIn (linkedin.com) – Professional networking profile setup (Task 2)
- Kaggle (kaggle.com) – Data science and ML platform (Task 2)
- HackerRank (hackerrank.com) – Coding practice platform (Task 3)
- Google Forms (forms.google.com) – Quiz creation and collaboration (Task 3)
- National Cyber Crime Portal – cybercrime.gov.in (referenced in Task 5)
- Cyber Crime Helpline – 1930 (24x7 national helpline, referenced in Task 5)
- Press Trust of India (PTI) – Reports on UPI fraud cases in India (background research for Task 5)

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